

GM CHEAT CARD — Dead in the Water

Clip to your clipboard. This is the only thing you need at-a-glance during the game. Everything else is in the GM Guide.

TIMING

Phase	Time	Rooms	Big beat
Arrival	15m	Living room	Hand out envelopes, read intro
1 Discovery	15m	Living room	The 4 auto-reveals, Solomon enters
2 First Suspicions	30m	+ downstairs, no bedrooms	Solomon's mutter → Hank confesses
3 Investigation	40m	+ bedrooms, Richard's room	Catherine, Eden (surface), Bella, Levi, Beau confess
4 Unmasking	30m	+ primary suite	Cody's photo → Eden corroborates → Sebastian breaks
5 Architect	15m	Everywhere	Christmas story → Vivi breaks
Toast	10m	Wherever	Out of character

Total ~2h 45m. Eat first, snacks during, cake at the Phase 4/5 break.

THE FOUR PHASE 1 AUTO-REVEALS (*read aloud*)

1. *"I found Mr. Crookshank in the shallows at 7:42 this morning. Dr. Langford confirms time of death between 11:30 last night and midnight."*
2. *"The brass dock cleat at the end of the dock is missing. The bolts are still in the wood."*
3. *"His leather portfolio was found open in the gazebo. The notarized envelope is gone."*
4. *"Solomon was on his perch in the gazebo. He has been... vocal." (Bring Solomon out. He screams.)*

CONFESSION ORDER

When	Who	Trigger
Phase 2	Hank	Solomon's mutter / green tweed scrap
Phase 3 Phase 3	Catherine Eden (surface only)	Burned manuscript page in ash Thank-you note on desk (<i>she does NOT yet reveal TURD</i>)
Phase 3 Phase 3	Bella Levi	Torn guestbook page in gazebo Marina boarding ticket under mattress
Phase 3	Beau	Empty bottle + full case under kayak
Phase 4	Cody	You turn to him: <i>"Anything you've been holding onto?"</i>

When	Who	Trigger
Phase 4	Eden (full)	After Cody — she corroborates TURD
Phase 4	Sebastian	First accusation vote — he breaks
Phase 5	Vivi	Christmas-story reveal → second vote → she breaks

SOLOMON LINES (*always shout*)

- **“WHERE’S MY ROOT BEER!”** — anytime energy dips
 - **“Don’t... don’t you talk about her like that...”** — Phase 2 (Hank’s gazebo line)
 - **“PRINCESS, PRINCESS, PRINCESS”** — Phase 3 or 4 (rattles Sophia)
 - **“Sixty MILLION dollars!”** — Phase 4 after TURD reveal
 - **“TURD! TURD! TURD!”** — Phase 4 (loud, proud)
 - **“Step outside for some air”** — Phase 4 (back at Sebastian)
 - **“Breathe. It’s done.”** — Phase 5 only (save for the end)
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ACCUSATIONS

- **No formal votes before Phase 4.** Players will accuse early — let them talk, don’t poll.
 - **Phase 4 ballot:** one name. Sebastian. He confesses.
 - **Phase 5 ballot:** one name. Vivi. She confesses.
 - **Someone votes Alexander:** *“Flattered. Not a Whitfield, no motive, please vote again.”*
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TROUBLESHOOTING

Problem	What to do
Room is quiet	Solomon. <i>“WHERE’S MY ROOT BEER!”</i>
Player checks out	Direct question to their character
Player overplays	<i>“Mr. Whitfield, I’m going to ask that we move on.”</i>
Hoarding clues	Enforce mandatory share. Press once, then disclose yourself.
Someone fingers Sebastian/Vivi too early	<i>“Strong theory. Can you prove it?”</i> — wait for the evidence
Emma reveals TURD in Phase 3	Roll with it but keep Cody’s photo as the visual proof
Ben (Cody) overwhelmed	Take a private 5-min break, tell him he can hand the phone over silently
Game running long	Cut Phase 3’s second search round
Game running short	10-min snack break between Phase 3 and Phase 4

CODY’S HERO TURN (*Phase 4 — most important moment in the game*)

Wait for **Clue 4-1 (envelope + TURD will)** AND **Clue 4-3 (binoculars)** to surface. Then turn to Ben:

“Cody. You’ve been very quiet this morning. Is there anything you’ve been holding onto? It’s okay if you do.”

Ben pulls out his phone. Shows the photo. Lets it land.

Then Eden (Emma) steps forward and corroborates.

Then you deliver the smoke-break receipt:

“Sebastian, you said you stepped out for a smoke at 11:30. I saw you come back in at 11:50. That’s a twenty-minute cigarette.”

Hand out Phase 4 ballots.

THE CHRISTMAS STORY (Phase 5 — the architect reveal)

After cake, set down your fork. To Daniel or Nicole:

“Hank. (Or: Catherine.) Did Vivi’s bonfire story sound familiar to you?”

If they recognize it, great. If not, bridge:

“You told me at breakfast you’d heard it before. At Christmas. Word for word. That was a twenty-minute story. Sebastian’s smoke break was twenty minutes long.”

Then to Sophia:

“Vivi. Would you mind if I looked through your overnight bag?”

She refuses. Hank intervenes. You retrieve Clue 5-1. Second ballot. Vivi breaks.

FINAL NARRATION (read or paraphrase at the very end)

“At 2:14 Saturday afternoon, Richard told Vivi he was leaving everything to TURD. She walked back to the boathouse and told Sebastian. They drowned for two hours and came back with a plan. At 11:30, Vivi started a story she had told before. At 11:35, Sebastian stepped out. He walked to the dock. He swung once. The cleat went into the lake. The envelope went into his blazer. He returned at 11:50. At 11:55, Vivi balled up a sticky note that said ‘breathe. it’s done.’ She told herself it was over. It was not over.”

Solomon, on cue: **“WHERE’S MY ROOT BEER!”**

End of game.

PRE-GAME 90-MIN SETUP CHECKLIST

- ☐ Place all 24 clues per locations in Clue Deck
 - ☐ Singe manuscript page over sink, drop in cooled fire pit
 - ☐ Plant envelope (Clue 4-1) in Sebastian’s blazer when he hangs it
 - ☐ Plant green tweed scrap (Clue 2-2) in Hank’s coat when he hangs it
 - ☐ Take the Cody phone photo of the “\$60M → TURD (final)” paper
 - ☐ Solomon on his perch in the gazebo
 - ☐ Clipboard with weekend schedule, keys, name tag
 - ☐ Stack of search permits + ballots ready
 - ☐ All 9 player envelopes labeled and stuffed
 - ☐ Lock the bedrooms / primary suite
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If overwhelmed: Solomon. Solomon fixes everything.